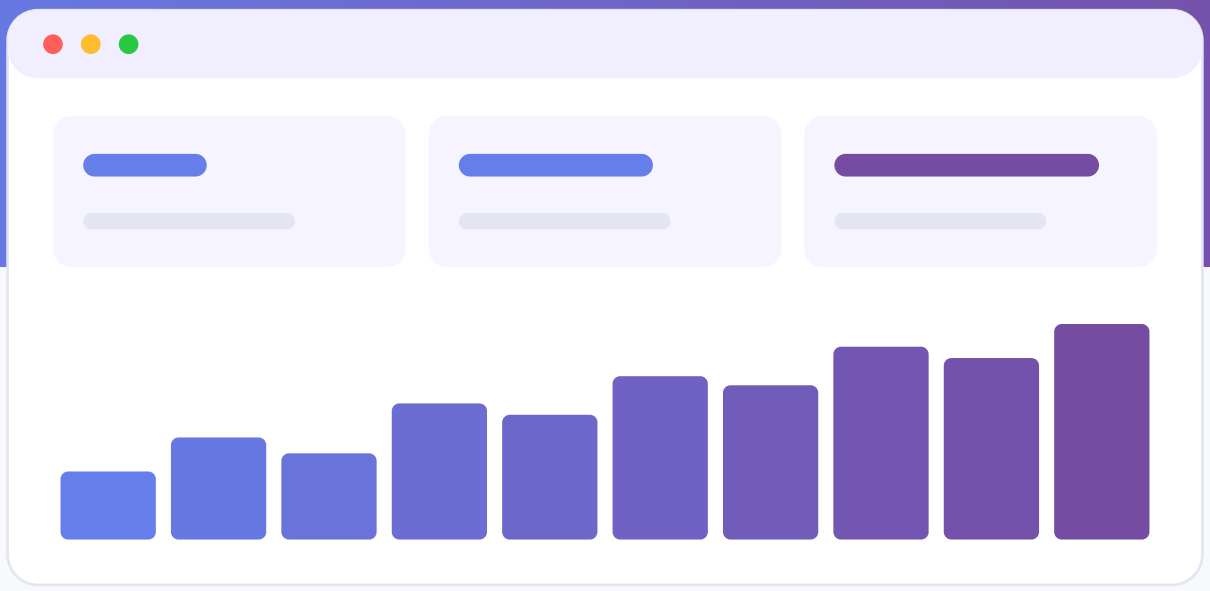
WEEK 18 · DIGITAL MARKETING & AI BOOTCAMP

Reporting & Data Storytelling

Executive dashboards, insights and stories that lead to decisions

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PART A

Why reporting matters

Reports that lead to decisions,
the people who read them,
and the Mauritian reality

SECTION 1

Why most marketing reports fail

Over the last 17 weeks you learned to run SEO, ads, social media, email and automation, and to measure them with GA4 and Data Studio. This week is about the last step, the one that decides whether your work is valued: **explaining results so that people act on them**. A marketer who can turn numbers into a clear story is trusted with bigger budgets; one who sends 40 charts every month is quietly ignored.



The five reasons reports are ignored

Problem	What it looks like	What to do instead
Data dump	Every metric the tool offers, 15 pages, no conclusion	Choose 5–7 KPIs linked to the business goal (Part B)
No comparison	"We had 3,812 sessions." Is that good or bad?	Always compare: target, last period, last year
Activity, not results	"We posted 24 times and ran 6 campaigns"	Lead with outcomes (sales, leads, bookings), then explain the activity
No "so what"	Charts without explanation	Each chart has a headline title and an insight (Part E)
No decision	The report ends with a table	End with recommendations, owners and the decision you need

What decision-makers actually need

A busy owner or manager asks four questions, in this order. A good report answers them in the first page:

1. **Are we on track?** Results against the target and against last year.
2. **Why?** The two or three things that explain most of the difference.
3. **What should we do?** Specific recommendations, with cost and expected effect.
4. **What do you need from me?** A decision, a budget, an approval, a piece of information.

> **The rule of this week:** a report is not a collection of numbers, it is an argument for a decision. If nobody would do anything differently after reading it, it was not worth producing.

Reporting vs analysis vs storytelling

Skill	Question it answers	Output	Covered in
Reporting	What happened?	Dashboards, scorecards, tables	Parts B–D
Analysis	Why did it happen?	Segments, comparisons, root causes	Week 11, Section 21
Storytelling	What should we do, and why should you believe me?	Executive summary, insight slides, presentation	Part E

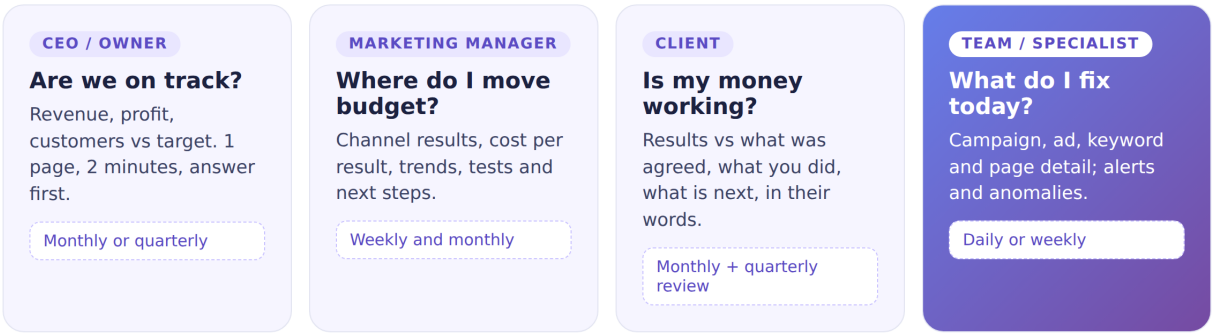
SECTION 2

Know your audience

The same data needs different reports for different people. Before you open Data Studio, write down who will read the report, what they decide, how much time they have and where they will read it (often a phone).

Four readers, four reports

Start every report by asking: who reads it, and what decision do they make?



Reader	Wants to know	Format that works	Avoid
Owner / CEO / board	Revenue, profit, customers, cash; on track or not; risks	1-page summary + 5–7 KPIs; 10-minute meeting each quarter	Channel jargon (CTR, CPM), long tables
Marketing manager	Which channels and campaigns work; where to move budget	Monthly dashboard with drill-downs; 3 insights and next steps	Vanity metrics without context
Client (agency or freelance)	Is the money working? What did you do? What is next?	Monthly report + quarterly review against the agreed KPIs	Platform-only numbers, unexplained drops
Specialist / team	What to fix today: keywords, ads, pages, errors	Live dashboard, alerts, detailed tables	Summaries without the detail they need
Finance	Spend vs budget, cost per result, return	Spreadsheet with clear definitions and VAT treatment	Platform "revenue" that does not match the accounts

Five questions to ask before you build anything

1. Who is the main reader? (Name one person, not "management".)
2. Which decisions will they make with this report? (Budget, staffing, stock, pricing, keep or stop a campaign.)
3. How often do they decide? That sets the reporting cadence (Section 3).
4. How much time will they give it, and on which device?
5. Which words do they use? "Bookings" or "key events"? "Clients" or "users"? Use their words.

> **Tip:** write the report title as the reader's question: "Are Facebook ads still worth it?" gets read; "Meta Ads Performance Report – Q3" gets filed.

SECTION 3

Report types and cadence

Not every report needs to be a big presentation. Match the type of report to the speed of the decisions. Most small businesses need three rhythms: a weekly pulse, a monthly performance report and a quarterly business review (QBR). Campaigns also get a post-mortem.

Type	Purpose	Typical content	Length and format
Daily / alert	Catch problems fast	Spend, leads, site down, tracking broken	Automatic alert, no report
Weekly pulse	Are we on track this month?	3–5 KPIs vs target month-to-date; anything unusual; actions this week	5 lines on WhatsApp or email + dashboard link
Monthly performance	Manage channels and budget	KPIs vs target and last year, channel results, tests, 3 insights, next month plan	1-page summary + 2–3 dashboard pages
Quarterly business review (QBR)	Strategic decisions	Results vs quarterly goals, trends, 3 insight slides, plan and budget for next quarter, risks	10–20 minute presentation + full report
Campaign post-mortem	Learn from a campaign	Objective, what we did, results vs plan, what worked, what to change	1–2 pages within 2 weeks of the end
Annual review	Strategy and budget for next year	Year vs year, customer and channel trends, lessons, next year's plan (Week 17)	Workshop with the owner or board

The campaign post-mortem in five headings

1. **Objective and target:** "Fête des Mères 2026: 120 cake orders at Rs 300 cost per order or less."
2. **What we did:** channels, budget, dates, creative, offer (one short paragraph).
3. **Results vs plan:** a small table with plan, actual and difference.
4. **What worked and what did not, and why:** two or three points each, with evidence.
5. **What we will do differently next time:** specific changes, written in the campaign calendar now.

Choosing the period

Report on **complete periods** (full weeks, full months) and wait for the data to settle: GA4 can take up to about 72 hours to process data, and ad platforms keep adding late conversions for days. For a monthly report, pull the numbers on the 3rd or 4th working day, not on the 1st. Google’s own help for GA4 scheduled emails suggests scheduling monthly reports on the 4th for the same reason.

> **Do not compare an unfinished period with a finished one.** "October so far: 9 days, 410 sessions; September: 30 days, 1,350 sessions, down 70%!" is a classic mistake. Compare month-to-date with the same days last month, or wait for the end of the month.

SECTION 4

Reporting in Mauritius

Reporting principles are universal, but the Mauritian market has some features that change how you report: small numbers, owners who read everything on WhatsApp, two or three languages, strong seasonality and a lot of sales that happen offline.

Local reality	What it means for your report
Small volumes (a business may get 20 leads or 60 orders a month)	Percentages jump around. Show absolute numbers next to percentages and compare longer periods (Section 11)
Many sales close on WhatsApp, by phone or in the shop	Online data shows only part of the result. Include the booking system, sales log or CRM as the source of truth (Section 8)
Owners read on their phone, often between meetings	Send a 5-line summary in the message, with the dashboard link; keep page 1 readable on a small screen
English, French and Kreol are all used	Write in the reader’s preferred language; many owners prefer the summary in French. Keep metric names consistent across languages
Strong seasons: tourism peaks, end-of-year bonus in December, festivals whose dates move each year	Compare with the same period last year, and note moving festivals (Divali, Eid, Chinese New Year, Easter)
Small teams, the marketer is often also the analyst	Automate the numbers (Section 19) so your time goes into the insights
Agencies and freelancers report to several clients	One template, one KPI dictionary per client, a fixed reporting calendar (Section 26)

> **In Mauritius:** the most common situation is an owner who receives a PDF of platform screenshots from an agency every month and never opens it. When you start a new job or client, ask: "What do you look at today, and what decision would you like to make with better information?" Then send a one-page report with three numbers, three insights and one question. You will stand out immediately.

A simple reporting calendar for a small business

When	What	Who	Time needed
Every Monday, 9:00	Weekly pulse: leads/sales month-to-date vs target, spend, one action	Marketer → owner (WhatsApp)	15 minutes
4th working day of the month	Monthly report: dashboard + 1-page summary	Marketer → owner and team	2–3 hours
First week of Jan, Apr, Jul, Oct	QBR: presentation + decisions for next quarter	Owner, marketer, sales, finance	1 day to prepare, 45-minute meeting
2 weeks after each big campaign	Post-mortem	Marketer → team	1–2 hours

PART B

Choosing what to measure

KPI trees, metrics that matter, targets, benchmarks and definitions everyone agrees on

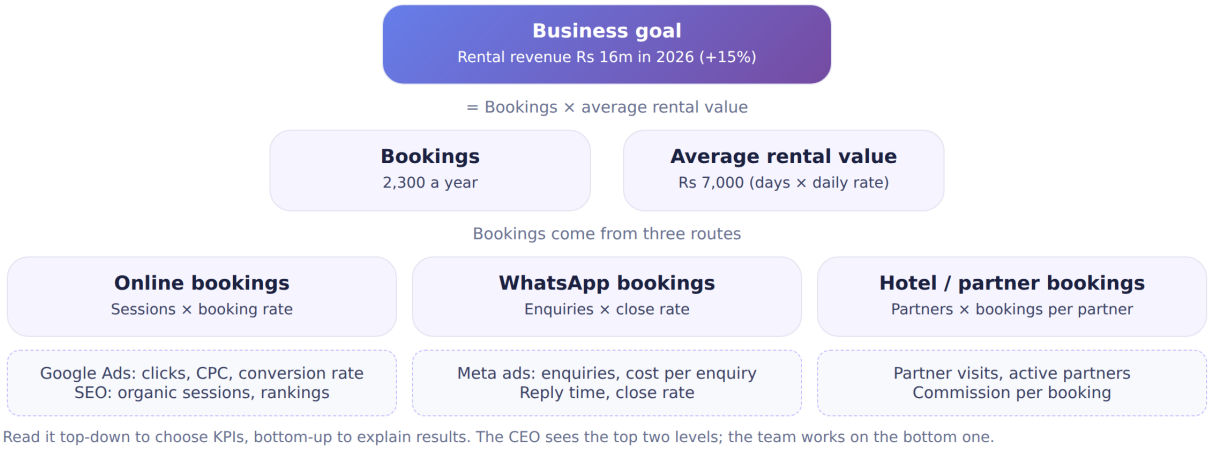
SECTION 5

From business goal to KPI tree

In Week 1 you learned what a KPI (key performance indicator) is, and in Week 17 you wrote a measurement framework. A **KPI tree** is the tool that connects the two: it breaks one business goal into the few numbers that drive it, down to the channel metrics your team can change.

The KPI tree: from business goal to channel metrics

Example: Azur Car Rental, Grand Baie (fictional)



Read it top-down to choose KPIs, bottom-up to explain results. The CEO sees the top two levels; the team works on the bottom one.

How to build a KPI tree in four steps

1. **Start with the money.** Write the business goal at the top as a number with a date: "Rental revenue Rs 16m in 2026".
2. **Split it with a formula.** Revenue = number of customers × average value. Bookings = sessions × booking rate, or enquiries × close rate. Each split must multiply or add back to the level above.
3. **Stop at what a team can act on.** The bottom level contains channel metrics: cost per click, conversion rate of a landing page, WhatsApp reply time, email click rate.
4. **Pick the KPIs.** Level 1–2 numbers go to the executive dashboard (5–7 KPIs). Level 3–4 numbers go to the marketing and team dashboards.

Worked example: Ti Gato cake shop, Rose Hill

Level	Metric	Formula / target (illustrative)	Who watches it
1 · Goal	Monthly revenue	Rs 450,000 (orders × average order value)	Owner
2 · Drivers	Orders; average order value (AOV)	300 orders × Rs 1,500	Owner, marketer
3 · Routes	Online orders; WhatsApp orders; shop orders	120 + 110 + 70	Marketer
4 · Channel	Website sessions, conversion rate; WhatsApp enquiries, close rate	6,000 sessions × 2% = 120; 220 enquiries × 50% = 110	Marketer, social media manager
4 · Channel	Instagram ad cost per enquiry; email click rate	Rs 60; 4%	Specialists

> **Tip:** the tree also explains results. If revenue is down, go down the tree: was it fewer orders or a lower AOV? If fewer orders, which route? If online, fewer sessions or a lower conversion rate? Three steps and you know where to look (Section 21).

SECTION 6

Choosing metrics that matter

Every tool offers hundreds of metrics. Two simple tests decide which ones earn a place in your report: is the metric **actionable** (would a change make us do something different?) and is it **leading or lagging** (does it predict results or confirm them?).

Which metrics deserve a place in the report?

Two tests: does it change a decision, and does it predict or confirm results?

	LEADING (predicts)	LAGGING (confirms)
ACTIONABLE	**Steer with these** Booking-page visits, WhatsApp enquiries, add-to-cart rate, quotes sent, reply time	**Judge with these** Bookings, revenue, cost per booking, ROAS, new customers, repeat rate
VANITY	**Context only** Impressions, reach, followers gained, video views, likes	**Avoid as headline** Total page views, "engagement" without a definition, all-time follower count

A vanity metric is not useless: it becomes useful when you connect it to a result (e.g. reach in the target area → enquiries).

Vanity metrics vs actionable metrics

A **vanity metric** looks impressive but does not tell you what to do: page views, followers, impressions, likes. An **actionable metric** is connected to a result and to a lever you control: cost per lead, booking rate of the landing page, revenue per email sent.

Vanity version	Actionable version	Why it is better
Followers gained: +850	Enquiries from Instagram: 64, cost per enquiry Rs 95	Linked to sales and to spend
Impressions: 1.2 million	Reach in the target area and frequency; enquiries per 1,000 reached	Shows whether the right people saw it, and what it produced
Website visits: 12,400	Sessions from target markets and their booking rate	Separates useful traffic from noise
Email open rate 48%	Clicks and revenue per email sent	Opens are inflated by Apple Mail privacy (Week 10)
Video views: 45,000	Viewers who then visited the site or messaged	Connects awareness to action

Leading vs lagging indicators

A **lagging indicator** confirms what already happened (revenue, bookings, profit). It is what the owner cares about, but by the time it moves it is too late to react. A **leading indicator** moves first and predicts the lagging one: enquiries, quotes sent, add-to-carts, booking-page visits, email sign-ups. A good dashboard shows both: lagging KPIs to judge the period, leading ones to steer the next weeks.

Business	Leading (steer)	Lagging (judge)
Guesthouse	Availability searches on the site, WhatsApp enquiries, quotes sent	Direct bookings, room nights, revenue per available room
Car rental	Quote requests, booking-page visits from target countries	Bookings, rental days, revenue
Training company	Brochure downloads, webinar sign-ups, calls booked	Enrolments, revenue per cohort
E-commerce shop	Add-to-cart rate, returning visitors, email sign-ups	Orders, revenue, repeat purchase rate

How many KPIs?

For an executive dashboard, **5 to 7**. Fewer and you miss something important; more and nobody remembers them. A good mix: 2–3 outcome KPIs (revenue, bookings, new customers), 1–2 efficiency KPIs (cost per booking, ROAS or MER from Week 12) and 1–2 leading KPIs (enquiries, conversion rate).

SECTION 7

Targets, benchmarks and definitions

A number without a comparison means nothing. "We got 85 leads" becomes useful when you add "target 100" or "last year 60". This section covers the three kinds of comparison and the definitions that make numbers trustworthy.

Three kinds of comparison

Comparison	Answers	Where it comes from	Watch out for
Target	Are we on plan?	The budget and plan (Week 17); split the annual target by month using last year’s seasonality	Targets set without data; changing the target mid-quarter
Previous period / last year	Are we improving?	Your own history	Seasonality and moving festivals; tracking changes between years
Benchmark	Are we normal?	Industry studies, platform averages, your other clients	Most benchmarks are from large markets; use them as a rough range, never as a target

Setting monthly targets from an annual goal

Do not divide the annual target by 12. Use last year's share of each month. If December produced 14% of last year's revenue, December's target is 14% of this year's goal. For the car rental business in the KPI tree: annual goal Rs 16m × 14% = Rs 2.24m target for December. If you have no history, use the best information you have (bookings calendar, tourist arrival patterns, sales team estimates) and correct after three months.

The KPI dictionary

A **KPI dictionary** (or data dictionary) is a short table that defines every KPI in the report: name, formula, source, owner and update frequency. It prevents the classic meeting where the owner, the agency and the accountant argue about three different "revenue" figures. Put it on the last page of the dashboard and in the appendix of the QBR.

KPI	Definition and formula	Source	Notes
Revenue	Rental revenue excluding VAT, by pick-up date	Booking system export	Not GA4 revenue; refunds deducted
Bookings	Confirmed bookings (deposit paid), all routes	Booking system	Cancellations removed at month end
Direct share	Bookings from website + WhatsApp ÷ all bookings	Booking system "source" field	Partners and hotels are not direct
Cost per booking	Ad spend (Google + Meta) ÷ bookings from paid channels	Platforms + GA4 + booking system	Label as estimate; uses GA4 channel split
Booking rate	Online bookings ÷ website sessions	GA4 key event "purchase"	GA4 data is a sample of reality (Section 12)
WhatsApp reply time	Median minutes to first reply, 8:00–20:00	WhatsApp Business / CRM	Measured weekly

Be precise about VAT, dates and cancellations. In Mauritius the standard VAT rate is 15%. If the ad platforms report revenue including VAT and the accountant reports it excluding VAT, the two will never match. Decide once, write it in the dictionary, and convert everything the same way (the Excel exercise practises this).

PART C

Data you can trust

Sources, cleaning, fair comparisons, small numbers and honest attribution

SECTION 8

Data sources, blending and the source of truth

A quarterly report usually combines four to six sources. Before you build anything, list them, decide which one is the **source of truth** for each KPI, and plan how they will be joined.

Source	Good for	Limits
Booking system, shop system, POS, CRM or sales log	The real number of sales, revenue, customers, cancellations	Often no channel information unless you capture it
GA4 (Weeks 2 and 11)	Website behaviour, channel split, funnels, key events	Misses refused cookies, ad blockers and offline sales
Google Ads, Meta Ads Manager, TikTok Ads	Spend, impressions, clicks, platform conversions	Each platform credits itself (Section 12)
Search Console	Search queries, impressions, average position	Sampled and anonymised queries
Email tool, WhatsApp Business, social insights	Sends, clicks, followers, messages	Different definitions in every tool
Spreadsheets (targets, offline sales, costs)	Anything not in a tool	Manual errors; needs one owner

One referee per KPI

For each KPI, write in the KPI dictionary which source is the referee. A sensible default: **money and customers from the business system**, **channel split and website behaviour from GA4**, **spend from the ad platforms**. Never take revenue from GA4 when the accounts show a different figure; instead show the GA4 channel split as a share and apply it to the real total if you need an estimate by channel (and label it "estimated").

Blending data

Blending means joining two sources on a common field, the **join key**, usually date, month or campaign name. In Data Studio you can blend up to five sources (Week 11, Section 24). In a spreadsheet you use SUMIFS or INDEX/MATCH on the same key. Three rules make blends work:

1. **The keys must match exactly:** "2026-07" and "Jul-2026" do not join; "Fete-des-meres" and "fete-des-meres" do not join. Agree formats in advance.
2. **Same level of detail:** join monthly targets to monthly results, not to daily data (or the target is repeated on every day and summed 30 times).
3. **Check totals after the join:** the blended revenue must equal the source revenue. If not, rows were lost or duplicated.

> **In Mauritius:** for many small businesses the "booking system" is a Google Sheet or a notebook. That is fine: ask for one row per sale with date, amount, product and "How did you hear about us?" (Google, Facebook, Instagram, friend, hotel, walk-in). After two months you can report sales by source, even for WhatsApp and phone orders.

SECTION 9

Cleaning data and consistent definitions

Real exports are messy: the same channel written five ways, test orders, VAT included in one place and not in another, duplicate rows. Cleaning is not glamorous, but a report built on dirty data loses trust the first time someone spots a mistake.

The cleaning checklist

Problem	Example	Fix
Inconsistent labels	"facebook / paid_social", "Facebook Ads", "ig / paid_social"	Mapping table: raw label → clean channel; INDEX/MATCH or a CASE field
Test and internal data	Orders from staging.site.mu, staff test bookings	Map to "Exclude" and filter out; GA4 internal traffic filter
Different VAT treatment	Shop revenue incl. 15% VAT, accounts excl. VAT	Convert once: excl. VAT = incl. VAT ÷ 1.15
Duplicates	Same order exported twice	Remove duplicates on order ID; check counts
Dates and time zones	Platform in UTC, shop in Mauritius time (UTC+4)	Set every tool to Mauritius time; compare full days
Currency	Meta account in USD, others in MUR	Convert with one documented rate per month
Missing values	Blank spend for a month	Find the real value; never treat blank as zero without checking

The mapping table

The most useful cleaning tool is a two-column table that maps each raw label to a clean name. You keep it in a separate tab, add new labels as they appear, and every report uses it. In a spreadsheet:

```
Clean channel  =INDEX(Map!$B$2:$B$20, MATCH(C5, Map!$A$2:$A$20, 0))
Revenue excl. VAT  =ROUND(E5/1.15, 0)
```

In Data Studio, the same logic is a calculated field with CASE (Week 11, Section 23), for example *CASE WHEN REGEXP_MATCH(Session source / medium, "(facebook|ig|instagram).*paid.*") THEN "Paid social" ... END*. Better still, fix the source: consistent lowercase UTMs (Week 2) prevent most of the mess.

> **Tip:** keep the raw export untouched in one tab and do all cleaning in formulas in another. If someone questions a number, you can show exactly how you got it.

SECTION 10

Time comparisons and seasonality

Most insights start with a comparison over time. Choosing the wrong comparison is the fastest way to tell a false story, especially in a seasonal market like Mauritius.

Comparison	Formula	Best for	Trap
MoM (month on month)	This month ÷ last month − 1	Fast feedback, non-seasonal businesses	Seasonality: December vs November says little
QoQ (quarter on quarter)	This quarter ÷ last quarter − 1	Progress of plans and tests	Q3 (European summer) vs Q2 in tourism
YoY (year on year)	This period ÷ same period last year − 1	Seasonal businesses; the fairest view	Tracking or website changes between years; moving festivals
Year to date (YTD)	Jan to now vs same months last year	Progress towards the annual goal	Early in the year, small numbers
Rolling 12 months / 3-month average	Sum or average of the last 12 or 3 months	Smoothing noisy, small numbers	Reacts slowly to real changes

Percent change vs percentage points

When a **rate** changes, say how many **percentage points** (pts) it moved, not a percentage. If the conversion rate goes from 2.0% to 2.5%, it rose by **0.5 pts**, which is also a **25%** relative increase. Both are correct, but mixing them up confuses readers. In reports: use % change for amounts (revenue +18%) and pts for rates (conversion rate +0.5 pts).

Worked example

	Q3 2025	Q2 2026	Q3 2026	QoQ	YoY
Revenue (Rs)	1,250,000	1,380,000	1,512,000	+9.6%	+21.0%
Orders	410	455	489	+7.5%	+19.3%
Conversion rate	2.20%	2.15%	2.02%	−0.13 pts	−0.18 pts

Formula reminders: % change = new ÷ old − 1. Change in pts = new rate − old rate. Illustrative figures for an online gift shop: revenue and orders grew, but a smaller share of visitors bought.

Seasonality in Mauritius

- **Tourism:** European summer holidays (July–August) and the October–December high season; Réunion and South African school holidays matter too. Hotels, car rental and excursions must compare YoY.
- **Local spending:** the end-of-year bonus in December, back to school in January, and festivals whose dates move each year (Chinese New Year, Cavadee, Easter, Eid, Divali). A Divali in October one year and November the next shifts sales between months and between quarters.
- **Weather:** the cyclone season (roughly November to April) can close shops and cancel trips for days; note it on the chart.
- **Pay days:** many salaries are paid at the end of the month, so weekly patterns repeat inside each month.

> **Tip:** compare equal periods: same number of days and, for weekly businesses such as restaurants, the same number of Fridays and Saturdays. A month with five weekends can beat one with four without any marketing change.

SECTION 11

Small numbers: be careful

Mauritius has about 1.2 million inhabitants, and many campaigns produce tens of results, not thousands. With small numbers, random variation is large, and percentage changes can look dramatic while meaning nothing.

Why small numbers mislead

If a landing page converted 3 visitors last month and 6 this month, the conversion count rose by 100%. But with numbers this small, the difference can easily be chance: a single group booking, a public holiday, a friend of the owner. Reporting "+100%!" creates false confidence; reporting "−50%!" the next month creates panic.

Practical rules

1. **Always show the count next to the percentage:** "conversion rate 4.0% (12 bookings from 300 sessions)".
2. **Avoid percentage changes on small bases.** As a rough rule, below about 30 results show absolute numbers ("6 bookings vs 3") and wait before concluding.
3. **Use longer periods** (quarter instead of month), rolling 3-month averages, or group similar campaigns together.
4. **Look for consistency:** a change that repeats for 3 months, or appears in several segments, is more likely to be real.
5. **Do not rank tiny segments:** "Best city: Mahébourg, 25% conversion rate" based on 1 booking from 4 sessions is not an insight.

A quick margin of error for a rate

For a conversion rate p measured on n sessions, the approximate 95% margin of error is **$1.96 \times \sqrt{p \times (1 - p) \div n}$**. Example: 40 bookings from 1,000 sessions is 4.0%. Margin = 1.96 × √(0.04 × 0.96 ÷ 1,000) = 1.96 × 0.0062 = **±1.2 pts**. So the true rate is probably between 2.8% and 5.2%. If next month shows 4.8%, that is within the noise: do not celebrate yet.

Sessions (n)	Conversion rate	Margin of error (95%)	Plausible range
200	4%	±2.7 pts	1.3% – 6.7%
1,000	4%	±1.2 pts	2.8% – 5.2%
5,000	4%	±0.5 pts	3.5% – 4.5%
20,000	4%	±0.3 pts	3.7% – 4.3%

> **Correlation is not causation.** "We posted more reels and sales went up" may be true, or sales went up because of the Divali season. Before you claim that an action caused a result, check other explanations (season, price, competitor, stock) and, when possible, test it (Section 12).

GA4 also hides very small rows when demographic data or Google signals are involved (data thresholds, Week 11). If a report shows fewer rows than expected, that may be the reason, not a fall in traffic.

SECTION 12

Platform vs GA4 vs blended numbers

"Meta says 31 bookings, Google Ads says 28, GA4 says 49, but we had 160 in total!" Different numbers are normal. An honest report explains which number is used for what, and never adds up numbers that overlap.

Why every tool shows a different number

Bookings in September for the same business (illustrative)

META ADS
31
Counts bookings after a click (7 days) or a view (1 day) of any Meta ad; modelled where tracking is blocked

GOOGLE ADS
28
Counts bookings after an ad click, up to its conversion window; credit to Google ads only

GA4
49
Website bookings from all channels; misses refused cookies and offline bookings

BOOKING SYSTEM
160
Every booking: website, WhatsApp, phone, hotels. The money in the bank

Wrong: add them up
31 + 28 = 59 "ad bookings", more than the 57 bookings made on the website: both platforms claim some of the same customers.

Right: one referee, clear labels
Business total from the booking system, channel split from GA4, platform numbers only for optimising inside each platform.

Why the numbers differ

Tool	How it counts	Typical effect
Meta Ads Manager	Conversions after a click or a view of a Meta ad within its attribution setting (the standard setting is 7-day click and 1-day view, plus engaged views of video ads); modelled where tracking is blocked	Higher than GA4 for Meta, because it counts views and its own touchpoints
Google Ads	Conversions after an ad click within the conversion window (30 days by default for website actions), reported on the date of the click	Credits Google ads only; late conversions are added to past days
GA4	Website key events, credit shared across channels with data-driven attribution (Week 11)	Lower total: misses refused cookies, blocked tags and offline sales
Business system	Every real sale	The highest and truest total, but often without a channel

How to report it honestly

- **Use the business system for totals** (revenue, bookings, customers).
- **Use GA4 for the channel split** of website results, with the attribution model written on the chart.
- **Use platform numbers for optimisation inside each platform** (which ad, which keyword), and label them "as reported by Meta" or "as reported by Google Ads".
- **Use blended efficiency metrics** for the big picture: **MER** (marketing efficiency ratio = total revenue ÷ total marketing spend) and **blended cost per acquisition** (total spend ÷ total new customers), both from Week 12.

- **Never change the attribution model to make a channel look better** from one report to the next. If you change it, say so and restate the previous period.

Incrementality basics

Attribution shares the credit for sales that happened. **Incrementality** asks a harder question: how many of these sales would **not** have happened without the ads? Some people who click a brand ad on Google would have found you anyway. The only reliable way to know is a **test**: pause or reduce a channel in one region or period (a holdout or geo test, Week 12) and compare with a similar control. Meta and Google also offer lift studies for larger budgets. In a QBR, one honest sentence is enough: "Meta reports 31 bookings; our test in August suggests about two thirds of them were incremental."

> **The honesty test:** would you be comfortable if the client’s accountant checked every number in your report against the bank account? If not, label the estimates, explain the gaps and show the source of every KPI.

PART D

Designing dashboards

Layout, charts, colour and accessibility, then the build in Data Studio and spreadsheets

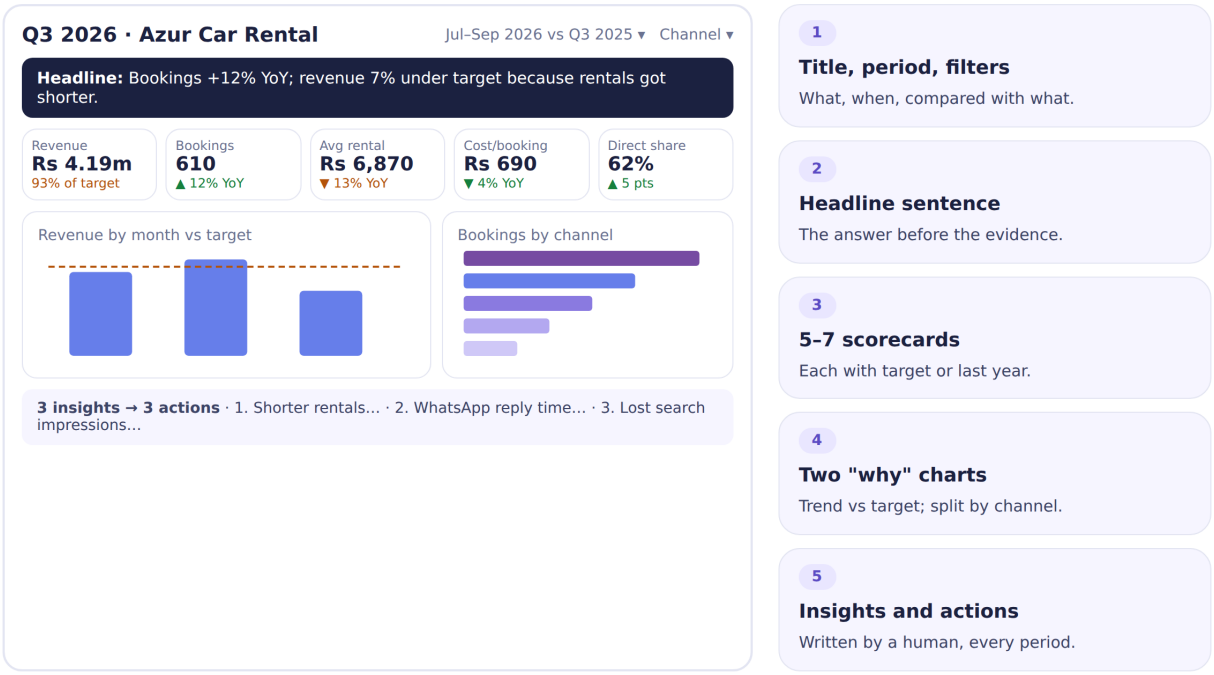
SECTION 13

Dashboard design principles

A dashboard is a tool for answering questions quickly. In Week 11 you built an analysis dashboard for yourself; an **executive dashboard** is different: one page, few numbers, readable in under a minute by someone who did not build it.

Anatomy of a one-page executive dashboard

Readers scan in a Z: top left first, then across and down



Eight principles

1. **One audience, one purpose.** The owner’s page answers "are we on track and why?". Detail for the team goes on later pages.
2. **Most important at the top left.** People scan in a Z pattern: title and period, then headline, then scorecards, then charts.
3. **Every number has a comparison:** target, previous period or last year, with an arrow or a coloured change.
4. **5–7 scorecards maximum** on the executive page, in the order of the KPI tree: outcome, then efficiency, then leading indicators.
5. **Two or three charts that explain the scorecards:** a trend against target and a split by channel or product.
6. **Text belongs on the dashboard:** a headline sentence at the top and 3 insights with actions at the bottom, written each period by a person.
7. **Consistency:** same colours for the same channel on every chart, same number formats (Rs 4.19m, 1.8%, 610), same date range everywhere.
8. **White space and alignment:** a grid, equal gaps, no borders around everything. Clutter hides the message.

The 5-second and 60-second tests

Show the dashboard to someone who has not seen it. After **5 seconds**, ask: "Are we doing well or badly?" After **60 seconds**: "What is the main reason, and what are we going to do?" If they cannot answer, simplify. This test takes two minutes and fixes more problems than any design theory.

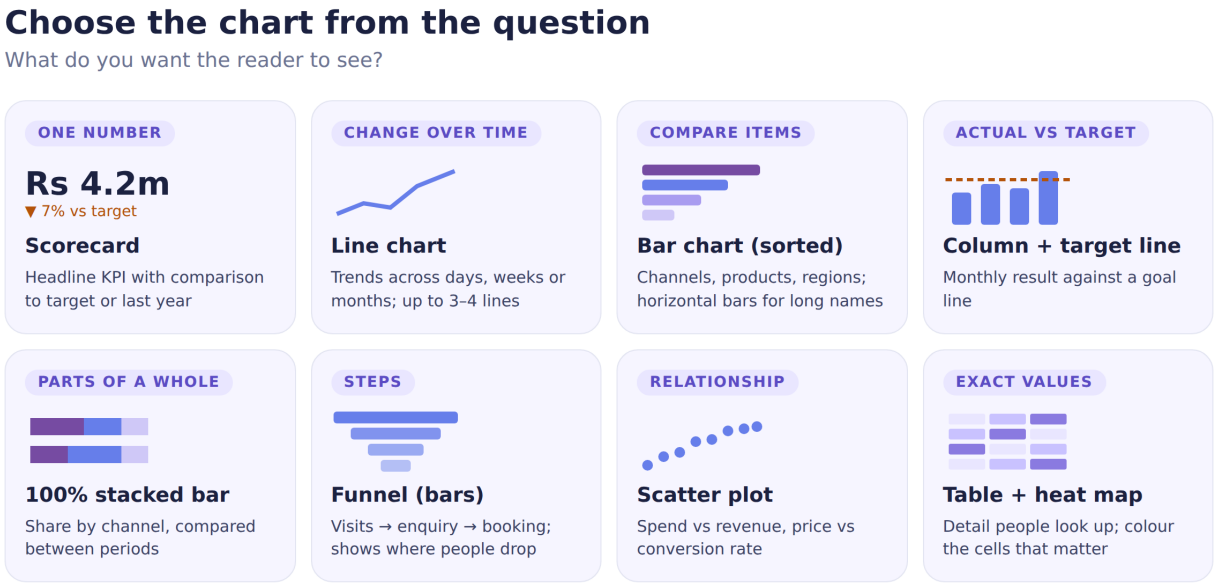
Number formatting

Do	Avoid
Rs 4.19m, Rs 690, 610 bookings	4190112.35, MUR 689.9871
1.8% (one decimal for rates)	1.78534%
▲ 12% vs Q3 2025 (comparison named)	+12% (compared with what?)
Bookings, Revenue, Cost per booking	sessionDefaultChannelGroup, eventCount
Jul–Sep 2026 written on the page	No date range visible

SECTION 14

Choosing the right chart

The right chart depends on the question, not on what looks impressive. Most business reporting needs only six chart types: scorecard, line, bar, column with target, stacked bar and table.



Question	Best chart	Settings that help
How are we doing on the main KPI?	Scorecard with comparison	Compact numbers; comparison to previous year or target
How did it change over time?	Line (or column for few periods)	Start the y-axis at zero for columns; max 3–4 lines
Which channel or product is biggest?	Horizontal bar, sorted largest first	Label values on the bars; highlight the one you talk about
Did we hit the target each month?	Column + target line (combo chart)	Target as a dashed line; actual in the main colour

Question	Best chart	Settings that help
How has the mix changed?	100% stacked bar, two or three periods	Same channel order and colours in both bars
Where do people drop off?	Funnel shown as bars	Show step conversion rates between bars
Is spend related to revenue?	Scatter plot	One dot per week or campaign; label outliers
What are the exact values?	Table with heat map or bars	Sort by the key metric; 10–15 rows; totals row

Charts to avoid

- **Pie and donut charts with more than 3–4 slices:** people cannot compare angles. Use a sorted bar instead. A pie is acceptable for one simple split (mobile 72% vs desktop 28%).
- **3D charts:** they distort the values. Always flat.
- **Dual y-axis charts** with different scales (sessions on the left, revenue on the right): the crossing of lines means nothing and readers draw false conclusions. Use two small charts.
- **Gauges and speedometers:** a lot of space for one number. A scorecard with "93% of target" says the same.
- **Truncated axes on bar charts:** starting at 500 instead of 0 makes a 5% difference look like 300%.

SECTION 15

Colour, accessibility and mobile

Colour is the strongest tool you have to direct attention, which is why it must be used sparingly. A dashboard should be readable by everyone, including colour-blind readers and people on a phone in bright sunlight.

Using colour with intention

1. **Grey for context, one colour for the message.** Show all channels in grey and the one you are talking about in your brand colour.
2. **Fixed colour per category:** if Google Ads is purple on page 1, it is purple on every page and in the slides.
3. **Red and green only for good and bad,** and not as the only signal: add ▲ ▼ arrows or "+/−" signs.
4. **Reverse the colours for costs:** cost per booking going down is good (green), not bad.
5. **Sequential shades** (light to dark of one colour) for heat maps; never a rainbow.

Accessibility

About 1 in 12 men and 1 in 200 women have some form of colour vision deficiency, most often difficulty telling red from green. The Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) recommend a contrast ratio of at least **4.5:1** for normal text and **3:1** for chart elements such as lines and bars. In practice:

- Dark text on light backgrounds; no light grey text for important numbers.
- Labels directly on lines and bars instead of a separate legend.
- Minimum font size around 12 px on screen for labels, larger for scorecards.

- Check your palette with a free contrast checker and a colour-blindness simulator before you publish.
- Describe the key chart in words in the text box (screen readers and people reading on WhatsApp both benefit).

Designing for mobile

Many owners open the dashboard link on a phone. Three options in Data Studio: (1) design a narrow version of page 1 (about phone width) only for mobile; (2) use a **responsive report**, a layout option in which sections and charts rearrange for phone, tablet and large screen (introduced in 2025 and labelled preview in Google's documentation at the time of writing; it cannot be applied to an existing freeform report); (3) rely on the scheduled PDF and a 5-line WhatsApp summary. For most small businesses option 3 plus a simple page 1 is enough.

> **Tip:** test on your own phone before you share: can you read every scorecard without zooming? If not, fewer scorecards and bigger numbers.

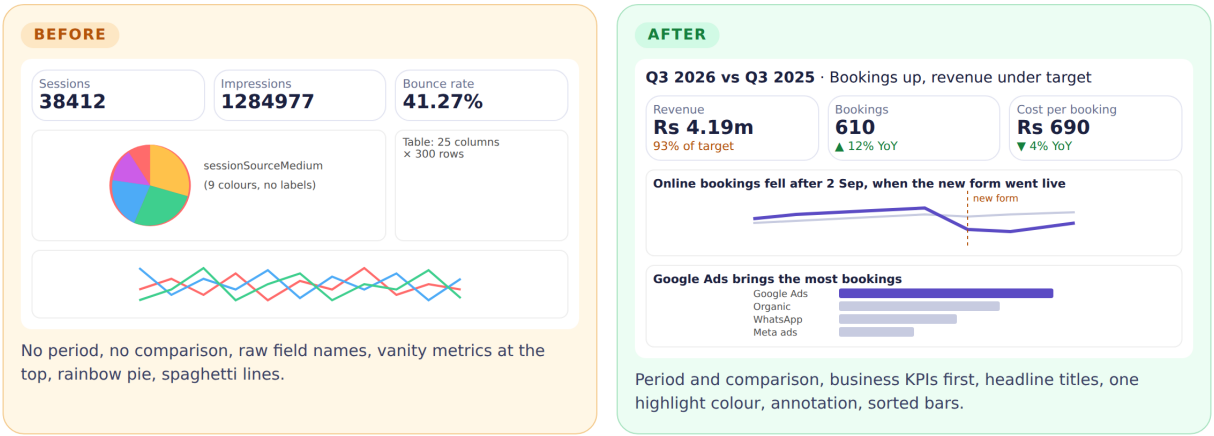
SECTION 16

Bad vs good: a dashboard makeover

Here is a dashboard many agencies still send in Mauritius, and the same information redesigned using Sections 13–15. The data did not change; only the choices did.

Before and after: the same dashboard, redesigned

Seven fixes that make a dashboard readable in under a minute



#	Before	After	Principle
1	No period shown	"Q3 2026 vs Q3 2025" in the title	Context first
2	Sessions, impressions and bounce rate at the top	Revenue, bookings, cost per booking	Business KPIs first
3	Raw numbers (38412, 1284977)	Rs 4.19m, 610, Rs 690 with comparisons	Formatting and comparison
4	Field names as titles ("sessionSourceMedium")	Headline titles that state the finding	One chart, one message
5	Rainbow pie with 9 slices	Sorted bar, one highlight colour	Right chart, colour with intention

#	Before	After	Principle
6	3 overlapping daily lines	One weekly line with an annotation for the form change	Annotation explains the "why"
7	300-row table on page 1	Detail table moved to page 3	One audience per page

> **Exercise in 10 minutes:** open the last report you received or sent. Count the numbers on page 1 that have no comparison, the charts whose title is a field name, and the colours used. Then list the three changes that would help the reader most.

SECTION 17

Building the executive dashboard in Data Studio

This walkthrough builds a one-page executive dashboard plus two detail pages. It assumes you know the basics from Weeks 2 and 11 (data sources, calculated fields, blends, controls). Data Studio is the name Google brought back in April 2026 for the tool previously called Looker Studio; the free version is enough for everything below.

Step 1 · Prepare the data sources

Source	Connector	What you take from it
GA4 property	Google Analytics (Google connector)	Sessions, key events, channel, landing page, device
Google Ads	Google Ads (Google connector)	Cost, clicks, conversions by campaign
Business results and targets	Google Sheets (Google connector)	Monthly revenue, bookings by source, targets, offline sales
Meta ads	Google Sheet with a monthly export from Ads Manager, or a paid partner connector	Spend, results, reach by campaign
Search Console	Search Console (Google connector)	Clicks and impressions for brand and non-brand queries

Keep the Google Sheet tidy: one header row, one row per month (and per channel if needed), a "Month" column written the same way as in GA4 (for example 202607 or 2026-07-01), numbers without text or currency symbols. Make the data sources reusable so a fix applies to every report.

Step 2 · Create the report and set the frame

1. Create → Report, add the GA4 data source, choose the layout (freeform, or responsive if you want automatic phone layouts).
2. Theme and layout: canvas width about 1,200 px, your brand colours as the theme, one font, background white.
3. Add a **date range control** at the top right with the default **Last quarter** and comparison **Previous year** (other presets include This quarter to date and Previous period).
4. Add one or two **drop-down controls** (Channel, Market) and a small text "Data: GA4, booking system, Google Ads, Meta. Revenue excl. VAT."

Step 3 · Scorecards that compare

1. Add 5–7 scorecards in one row (or two rows of three on a narrow page).

2. For each: turn on the comparison (it follows the comparison date range), show the change as a percentage, choose compact numbers, and set the colours so that an increase in cost metrics shows as negative.
3. For "% of target", blend the results sheet with the targets sheet on Month and create a calculated field: *SUM(Revenue) / SUM(Target revenue)*. Format as percent.
4. Rename every metric in plain words ("Bookings", not "Key events").

Step 4 · The "why" charts

- **Combo chart:** monthly revenue as columns and the target as a line (from the blended data), so the reader sees which month missed.
- **Bar chart:** bookings or revenue by channel, sorted descending, with the comparison period shown as a lighter bar if useful.
- **Optional time series:** weekly online bookings with the comparison period, for spotting breaks such as a broken form.
- Write each chart title as a headline in a text box above it (Section 23) and update it every period.

Step 5 · Detail pages and the insight box

Page 2 (marketing manager): table by channel with sessions, bookings, conversion rate, spend, cost per booking and ROAS, with heat maps; campaign table from Google Ads and Meta. Page 3 (team): landing pages, devices, funnel steps, search queries. On page 1, add a text box with the **headline** at the top and **3 insights → 3 actions** at the bottom.

Step 6 · Share, schedule and export

Task	How (at the time of writing)
Share	Share → invite people as viewers, or get a view-only link. Check the data source credentials: with owner's credentials, viewers see the data without their own GA4 access
Schedule by email	Share → Schedule delivery: recipients (up to 50), pages, start date and repeat (no more than daily on the free version). Recipients get a PDF and a link
Export for slides	File → Download as PDF; or export a single chart as a PNG image (added in 2026) to paste into Google Slides or PowerPoint
Let viewers refresh	Editors can allow viewers to refresh the data manually (2026 setting), useful before a meeting
Pro features	Data Studio Pro (paid) adds hourly schedules, delivery to Google Chat and Slack, several schedules per report and Conversational Analytics (questions in plain language)

Before you share: check that page 1 loads in a few seconds (too many GA4 charts can hit the GA4 data API limits and show errors), that every scorecard has a comparison, that numbers match the source of truth, and that no personal data (names, emails, phone numbers) appears in any table.

SECTION 18

Spreadsheets for reporting

Many reports are still built in Google Sheets or Excel, and even with Data Studio you will use a spreadsheet to clean data, add offline sales and targets, and check numbers. Three skills cover most needs: SUMIFS summaries, pivot tables and clean charts.

SUMIFS: the reporting formula

SUMIFS adds the values that meet one or more conditions. With a clean data tab (one row per month, channel and source), a summary table builds itself:

```
Revenue for Paid search in July:
=SUMIFS(Data!$G:$G, Data!$H:$H, "Paid search", Data!$B:$B, "Jul 2026")
With the channel in A5 and the month in C3:
=SUMIFS(Data!$G:$G, Data!$H:$H, $A5, Data!$B:$B, C$3)
```

The dollar signs lock the column or row so you can copy the formula across the whole table. Ratios (conversion rate, ROAS) are then calculated from the totals in the summary, never by averaging rates.

Pivot tables in 5 steps

1. Select the clean data (with headers). Google Sheets: Insert → Pivot table. Excel: Insert → PivotTable.
2. Rows: Channel. Columns: Month. Values: SUM of Revenue.
3. Add a second value (SUM of Sessions) or a calculated field (Sheets: Values → Add → Calculated field, for example =Revenue/Sessions).
4. Sort by the grand total, descending. Filter out "Exclude".
5. Show values as % of column total to see the channel mix by month.

Charts in a spreadsheet that look professional

- Delete the chart title and replace it with a headline in a cell above, or edit the title to state the finding.
- Remove gridlines or make them light grey; remove the legend when there is one series.
- One highlight colour, the rest grey; data labels on the key points only.
- Use SPARKLINE in Google Sheets (=SPARKLINE(B2:M2)) for mini trend lines in a KPI table.
- Conditional formatting: colour scale on a % change column, or icons (arrows) for up and down.

Getting data into the spreadsheet

From	How
GA4	Share icon on a standard report → Download file (CSV or Google Sheets); or connect the Sheet in Data Studio instead of the other way round
Google Ads, Meta	Download reports as CSV, or schedule emailed reports from the platform
Booking or shop system	Monthly CSV export; keep a fixed column order
Automation	Zapier or Make to append new leads or sales to the Sheet (Week 14)

Tip: the Week 18 Excel exercise practises exactly this workflow: clean a raw export with a mapping table, build KPI changes, summarise by channel and month with SUMIFS, choose charts and write insights.

SECTION 19

Automation and AI assistance

The numbers should be automatic; the thinking should not. Automate the collection and formatting of data so your time goes into finding insights and writing recommendations. AI can help with both, as long as you check every number.

What to automate

Task	Tool	Notes
Collect data monthly	Data Studio connectors; Google Sheets with scheduled imports; partner connectors	Set up once; check totals each month
Send the dashboard	Data Studio scheduled delivery (PDF + link)	Schedule a few days after month end
Send a standard GA4 report	GA4 scheduled emails (Admin → Scheduled emails; administrators only)	PDF or CSV, daily to quarterly, up to 50 recipients
Alert on problems	Ad platform rules; GA4 custom insights; Zapier/Make	"Spend over Rs 5,000 with zero leads today"
Weekly pulse message	Zapier or Make: Sheet → AI summary → email or Slack (Week 14)	Human check before it goes to a client

Using AI assistants safely

AI assistants (ChatGPT, Gemini in Google Sheets, Copilot in Excel, Claude and others) are good at: suggesting formulas, spotting unusual rows, drafting the first version of an executive summary, rewriting for a different audience or language (English to French), and proposing chart types. Data Studio Pro's Conversational Analytics answers questions in plain language over connected data. They are bad at: knowing your business context, and getting every number right.

1. **Give context and definitions:** paste the KPI dictionary and the period, and say who the reader is.
2. **Never paste personal data** (customer names, phone numbers, emails) into a public AI tool. Use aggregated tables only (Section 26).
3. **Check every number** the AI writes against the source table. AI tools can invent or miscalculate figures with total confidence.
4. **Check the logic:** AI tends to explain changes with plausible but unproven causes. Keep only the explanations you can support with evidence.
5. **Rewrite in your own voice** and take responsibility: the client trusts you, not the tool.

A prompt that works

```
You are helping me write the executive summary of a quarterly marketing report
for the owner of a car rental company in Mauritius. Reader: busy owner, reads on
her phone, prefers short sentences. Below are the KPIs (Q3 2026 vs Q3 2025 and
vs target) and our KPI definitions. Write 5 lines: 1) headline result vs target,
2) the main reason, 3) the two other insights, 4) the decision we need, 5) the
main risk. Use only the numbers in the table. If something cannot be explained
from the data, say "to investigate". [paste table]
```

> AI output is a draft. In this course, any AI-assisted report must be checked line by line against the data before it is sent. Mention in your process notes which parts were AI-assisted.

PART E

From numbers to story

Insights, root causes, narrative,
executive summaries and
presenting with confidence

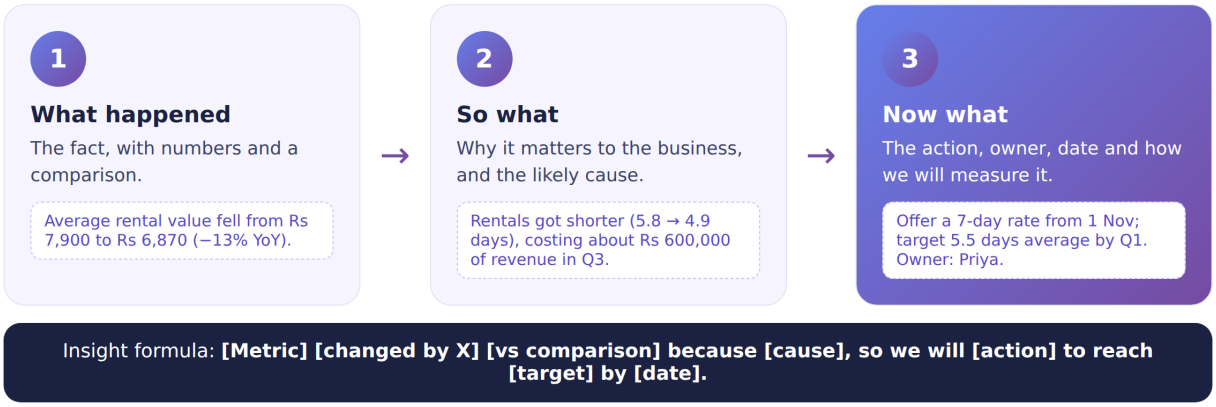
SECTION 20

From numbers to insights

An **observation** says what happened ("bookings rose 12%"). An **insight** explains why it matters and what to do about it. Most reports stop at observations. Your value as a marketer is in the next two steps.

From number to action: What → So what → Now what

An observation is not an insight until it explains and recommends



Insight formula: **[Metric] [changed by X] [vs comparison] because [cause], so we will [action] to reach [target] by [date].**

Observation, insight, recommendation

Level	Example	Useful?
Observation	Email revenue was Rs 245,000 in Q3.	Barely: no comparison, no meaning
Comparison	Email revenue rose 38% vs Q2.	Better: shows a change
Insight	Email revenue rose 38% because the new abandoned-cart flow brought 61 orders; email now earns the most revenue per session of any channel.	Yes: cause and significance
Recommendation	Add a browse-abandonment flow in November (owner: Yannick) and target Rs 300,000 from email in Q4.	Yes: action, owner, target

What makes a good insight

- **Relevant:** connected to a KPI the reader cares about, not an interesting detail.
- **Specific:** numbers, periods, segments. "Mobile users from Réunion" beats "some users".
- **Explained:** it states the probable cause and the evidence for it.
- **Actionable:** it leads to a decision someone can take this month.
- **Sized:** it says how much is at stake: "about Rs 600,000 of revenue" makes people listen.

Where to look for insights: five questions

Question	Example finding
What changed most vs target or last year?	Average rental value −13% YoY while bookings +12%
Which segment explains most of the change?	The fall comes from Réunion visitors (short stays), not Europeans
What is unusually good or bad?	Email: 3% of sessions but 12% of revenue
What is the trend inside the period?	Meta cost per enquiry rose every month of the quarter
What did we change, and what happened after?	After the new booking form went live (2 Sep), online bookings fell 32%

SECTION 21

Finding the why: root cause and segmenting

When a KPI moves, managers ask "why?". Guessing is common; a simple, structured search is better. You already have the tools: the KPI tree (Section 5) and segments (Week 11).

Step 1 · Check the data first

Before looking for business causes, rule out measurement problems: did tracking break, did a tag change, was a filter added, is the period complete, did a currency or VAT setting change? A sudden jump or drop on a single day is usually a data problem, not a market change.

Step 2 · Go down the KPI tree

Decompose the change. Revenue = bookings × average value. If revenue fell 3% while bookings rose 12%, the cause is the average value, not the number of customers. Then decompose average value = days × daily rate: days fell from 5.8 to 4.9 while the rate rose slightly. You have found the driver in two steps.

Step 3 · Segment

Segment by	Typical question	Where
Channel and campaign	Did one channel cause the drop?	GA4 traffic acquisition; ad platforms
Device	Is it a mobile-only problem (form, speed)?	GA4 with device dimension
Market / country / region	Locals vs tourists; north vs south	GA4 country/city; booking system
New vs returning customers	Are we acquiring or only retaining?	GA4; CRM
Product or service	Did one product fall?	Shop or booking system
Landing page	Did one page stop converting?	GA4 landing page report

Step 4 · Look for the event

Write a simple **change log** with dates: price changes, new website pages, tracking changes, campaigns started or stopped, stock problems, public holidays, cyclones, competitor promotions. Put the most important events as annotations on your trend charts. Many "mysteries" are explained by matching the date of the break with the log.

The five whys, applied

1. Why did revenue miss the target? Average rental value fell 13%.
2. Why did the average value fall? Rentals got shorter (4.9 days vs 5.8).
3. Why were rentals shorter? More bookings came from Réunion visitors, who stay 3–4 days.
4. Why more Réunion visitors? Our Meta campaign targeted Réunion heavily from June (cheap clicks).
5. Why did we not see it earlier? We reported bookings, not rental days or value. **Root cause found: targeting and the KPI choice.**

> **Tip:** stop when you reach something you can act on. "Because tourists exist" is too far; "because our targeting favoured short-stay markets" is actionable.

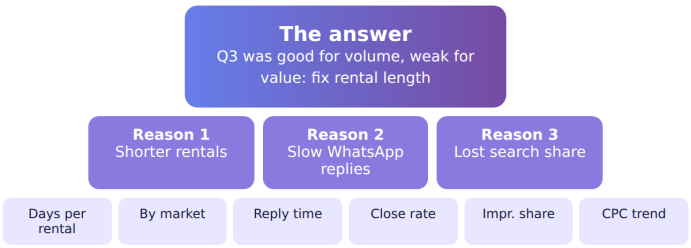
SECTION 22

Data storytelling and the pyramid principle

Data storytelling means combining **data**, **visuals** and a **narrative** so that the reader understands and remembers the message and acts on it. Data alone informs; data with a story persuades.

The pyramid principle: answer first

Busy readers want the conclusion, then the reasons, then the evidence



Detective story (avoid)

"First we looked at sessions… then channels… then… and finally we found that…" The CEO stops reading on slide 3.

Pyramid (use)

Slide 1 gives the answer and the decision needed. Each next slide supports one reason. The appendix holds the detail.

Answer first: the pyramid principle

The pyramid principle, made famous by the consultant Barbara Minto, says: start with the answer, then give the supporting reasons, then the evidence. Executives can stop reading at any level and still have the main message. It is the opposite of the "detective story" most of us were taught at school, where the conclusion comes last.

A simple narrative arc for business reports

Part	Question it answers	Car rental example
1 · Context	Where were we, what was the goal?	Q3 target Rs 4.5m revenue; peak European season; new booking form in September
2 · Complication	What happened that matters?	Bookings +12% but revenue 7% below target: rentals got shorter
3 · Resolution	What do we do now?	Shift Meta budget from Réunion to European pre-arrival targeting; 7-day rate; fix the mobile form
4 · Ask	What do we need from you?	Approve Rs 40,000 budget move and the 7-day price from 1 November

Before and after: the same message

Before (detective story)	After (answer first)
"This quarter we had 38,400 sessions, up 9%. Organic search grew 14%. Google Ads had a CTR of 7.2%. Meta reached 210,000 people. Email open rate was 46%. Bookings were 610, up 12%. Revenue was Rs 4.19m, 93% of target. Average rental value decreased."	"We missed the Q3 revenue target by 7% even though bookings grew 12%, because rentals got shorter. We propose moving Rs 40,000 of Meta budget to European pre-arrival campaigns and launching a 7-day rate, which should bring the average rental back to 5.5 days by Q1. We need your approval today."

Three storytelling techniques that work with numbers

- **Comparison:** "That is the revenue of 90 extra rentals" or "as much as the whole Google Ads budget for two months" makes numbers concrete.
- **One customer's journey:** describe a typical customer ("a couple from Lyon, books 6 weeks ahead, 8 days") before showing the segment data.
- **Tension and resolution:** show the problem clearly (the gap to target) before the solution. Do not hide bad news in the middle.

SECTION 23

Headlines, annotation and one message per chart

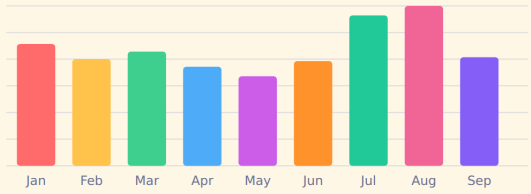
The quickest way to improve any report is to rewrite the chart titles. A title that names the data ("Revenue by month") makes the reader do the work; a headline that states the finding ("September revenue missed target by 18%") does the work for them.

One chart, one message

Same data: online bookings per month, Azur Car Rental 2026 (illustrative)

DEFAULT

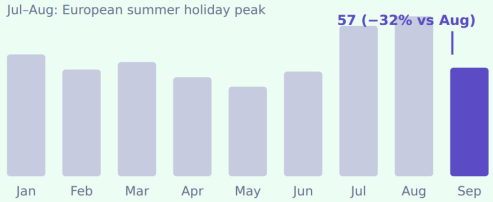
Bookings by Month



Generic title, rainbow colours, heavy gridlines: the reader must work out the story.

STORY

September online bookings fell 32% after the new booking form went live on 2 Sep



Headline title states the finding; grey for context, one colour for the point; a short annotation.

Writing headline titles

Descriptive title (avoid)	Headline title (use)
Sessions by channel	Organic search is now our largest source of visits (+14% YoY)
Cost per lead – Meta	Meta cost per enquiry rose every month, from Rs 82 to Rs 131
Conversion rate by device	Mobile visitors book half as often as desktop visitors
Email performance Q3	The abandoned-cart flow made email our most profitable channel
Revenue vs target	Two of three months hit target; September missed by 18%

One chart, one message

1. Decide the single message before you choose the chart.
2. Remove everything that does not support it: extra series, gridlines, legend, decimals, 3D, borders.
3. Highlight the data point that carries the message in your accent colour; everything else grey.
4. Add **annotations**: a short label on the chart for events ("new form 2 Sep", "cyclone 14 Feb", "price +10%").
5. If you need to show two messages, make two charts.

Annotation in Data Studio, Sheets and Slides

Data Studio and spreadsheets have limited annotation tools, so most analysts export the chart (Data Studio can export a chart as a PNG image) and add the headline, highlight and annotation in Google Slides or PowerPoint. In Data Studio itself, use a text box for the headline and a small text label or shape near the point; in Google Sheets, add a data label on one point and edit its text.

SECTION 24

Writing the executive summary

The executive summary is the most-read part of any report and often the only part. It should fit on one screen and be understandable without the charts.

The 5-line executive summary

Line	Content	Example
1 · Headline	Result vs target and last year, in one sentence	Q3 revenue Rs 4.19m: 93% of target and −3% YoY, despite bookings +12%.
2 · Main reason	The driver that explains most of the gap	Rentals got shorter (4.9 days vs 5.8) as Meta brought more short-stay Réunion visitors.
3 · Other insights	Two further findings, one line	Fast WhatsApp replies double the close rate; we lose 35% of Google search impressions to budget.
4 · Recommendation and ask	What we will do and the decision needed	Move Rs 40,000 from Meta Réunion to Google Ads Europe and launch a 7-day rate: approval needed today.
5 · Outlook / risk	What to expect, what could go wrong	Q4 target Rs 5.2m is reachable if average rental returns to 5.5 days; risk: airline capacity from Europe.

Writing rules

- Write it **last**, after the analysis, but put it **first**.
- Short sentences, active voice, no jargon: "bookings", not "key events"; "people who saw the ad", not "reach".
- Every number has a comparison; round sensibly (Rs 4.19m, 12%).
- Say clearly if something is bad. Owners respect honesty; they lose trust when bad news is hidden on page 9.
- Use the reader's language. A French version for a French-speaking owner is worth the 15 minutes.

For WhatsApp: the 3-line version

```
Q3: Rs 4.19m (93% of target), bookings +12% but rentals shorter (4.9 days).
Proposal: move Rs 40k from Meta Réunion to Google Europe + launch a 7-day rate.
Full report and dashboard: [link]. Can we decide at Thursday's meeting?
```

SECTION 25

Presenting: the 10-minute QBR

A quarterly business review (QBR) is a meeting to make decisions about the next quarter. Your slides support the conversation; they do not replace it. Send the full report the day before so the meeting can focus on the decisions.

The 10-minute quarterly business review

Five slides, then questions. Send the full report the day before.

1 · Answer 1 min	2 · Scorecard 1.5 min	3 · Three insights 4.5 min	4 · Plan + ask 2 min	5 · Risks 1 min
Executive summary Headline, result vs target, the decision you need today.	**Dashboard page** 5–7 KPIs vs target and last year. Do not read every number.	**Insight slides** One slide each: headline, one chart, so what, now what.	**Next quarter** Priorities, budget split, tests, targets, owners.	**Risks and data notes** What could go wrong; tracking limits; what is estimated.

Leave at least 10 minutes for discussion: the meeting exists to make decisions, not to read slides.

The insight slide

Each of your three insight slides follows the same structure, so the audience knows where to look:

Zone	Content
Headline (top)	The insight as a full sentence: "Fast WhatsApp replies double our close rate"
Chart (middle, 60% of the slide)	One chart, one highlight, one annotation
So what (right or bottom)	Why it matters, with the size of the opportunity: "Worth about 40 bookings a quarter"
Now what (bottom)	The action, owner, date and how it will be measured
Source line (small)	"Source: WhatsApp Business + booking system, Jul–Sep 2026; 1,150 enquiries"

Delivering it

- **Rehearse once with a timer.** 10 minutes means about one minute per slide plus questions.
- **Speak the headline, then point to the evidence:** "Fast replies double our close rate. You can see it here: under 15 minutes, 22%; after an hour, 9%."
- **Do not read numbers aloud** from tables; let people look while you explain the meaning.
- **Ask for the decision explicitly** at the end of the plan slide: "Do we agree to move Rs 40,000 from 1 November?"
- **Put the detail in an appendix:** KPI dictionary, channel tables, methodology. Jump there only if asked.

Handling questions

Situation	What to do
You do not know the answer	"Good question. I don't have that split here; I'll send it by Friday." Then do it.
Someone challenges a number	Show the source and definition (KPI dictionary). If you made a mistake, say so and correct it.
"Why don't we just do more of X?"	Answer with data and the trade-off: diminishing returns, budget, capacity.
The discussion goes off-topic	"Let's note that and come back to it after the decisions."

Presenting bad news

1. **Say it early and plainly:** "We missed the target by 7%." Never bury it.
2. **Explain the cause** with evidence, without blaming people or "the algorithm".
3. **Show what you have already done** and what you propose, with expected effect.
4. **Separate what you control from what you do not** (flights, cyclones, competitors), but do not use outside factors as an excuse for everything.
5. **Commit to a checkpoint:** "We will review the 7-day rate after four weeks."

> **In Mauritius:** in many Mauritian companies the QBR is with the owner or the managing director in person, sometimes with family members who run other parts of the business. Bring two printed copies of the one-page summary; some decision-makers prefer paper. Keep the slides in English or French depending on the audience, and be ready to explain a term in Kreol if that helps the conversation.

SECTION 26

Client reporting, ethics and privacy

Agencies and freelancers in Mauritius often lose clients not because results are bad, but because the client does not understand what they are paying for. Good reporting is part of the service, and it comes with responsibilities.

A client reporting system for freelancers and agencies

Element	Good practice
Agree KPIs at the start	Put 3–5 KPIs, targets, data sources and the report calendar in the proposal or contract
One template per client	Same structure every month: summary, KPIs, what we did, insights, next month, data notes
Client owns the accounts	GA4, ad accounts, Data Studio report owned by the client's business account; you are a user
Report on their goals, not your activity	Leads, sales and cost per result first; tasks completed at the end
Fixed rhythm	Monthly report by the 5th working day; QBR every quarter; post-mortem after each campaign
Price it in	Reporting and meetings take hours each month: include them in your monthly fee

Ethics: honest reporting

- **No cherry-picking:** do not show only the metrics or periods that look good. If a KPI agreed in the contract is down, it stays in the report.
- **No moving goalposts:** keep the same attribution model, definitions and comparison periods; if you change them, say so.
- **Label estimates and modelled data** ("estimated", "as reported by Meta", "modelled conversions").
- **Show the axis from zero** on bar charts and do not stretch scales to exaggerate.
- **Declare conflicts of interest:** if your fee depends on ad spend, be careful when recommending more spend and show the evidence.

Privacy in reports

Reports should contain **aggregated** data. Under the Mauritius Data Protection Act 2017 (and the GDPR for European customers), personal data must be processed lawfully, kept secure and limited to what is necessary. In practice:

☐ No customer names, phone numbers, emails or WhatsApp screenshots with visible names in reports or slides

☐ No exports of personal data into AI tools or personal Google accounts

☐ Small segments (for example 2 customers from one village) are not shown if people could be identified

☐ Dashboards shared with "anyone with the link" contain no personal or confidential data

☐ Access removed when a team member or agency leaves; reports owned by the business

☐ Client data used only for that client; benchmarks shared with others are anonymised and aggregated

PART F

Put it to work

A case study, FAQ, your Quarterly Report, templates, checklists and glossary

SECTION 27

Case study: Azur Car Rental’s quarterly report

"Azur Car Rental" is a fictional but realistic car rental company in Grand Baie with 45 cars. Customers are European tourists, visitors from Réunion and local residents. Bookings come from the website, WhatsApp, hotel partners and walk-ins. Marketing: Google Ads, Meta ads, SEO and a WhatsApp Business account. All figures are illustrative.

Before: the report nobody read

Every month the agency sent an 18-page PDF: screenshots from Google Ads, Meta and GA4, 64 charts, impressions and clicks on page 1, no targets, no comparison with last year and no recommendations. The owner admitted she had stopped opening it. In the September meeting she asked one question the report could not answer: "Bookings are up, so why is there less money in the account?"

What the marketer did (one week)

1. **KPI tree and dictionary (Sections 5–7):** revenue = bookings × average rental value; agreed 6 KPIs with the owner; booking system as the referee for revenue and bookings; revenue excluding VAT by pick-up date.
2. **Data (Sections 8–9):** monthly export of the booking system to a Google Sheet with a "source" column; mapping table for channel names; targets by month from last year’s seasonality.
3. **Dashboard (Sections 13–17):** a one-page Data Studio executive dashboard plus a channel page and a team page; scheduled PDF on the 4th working day.
4. **Analysis (Sections 20–21):** went down the KPI tree, segmented by market and route, and matched breaks with the change log.
5. **Story (Sections 22–25):** 5-line executive summary, one dashboard slide, three insight slides, one plan slide, one risk slide.

The executive dashboard: Q3 2026

KPI	Q3 2026	Q3 2025	Change	Target	Status
Revenue (excl. VAT)	Rs 4.19m	Rs 4.31m	−3%	Rs 4.50m	93% of target
Bookings	610	545	+12%	600	On target
Average rental value	Rs 6,870	Rs 7,900	−13%	Rs 7,500	Below
Average rental length	4.9 days	5.8 days	−0.9 days	5.5 days	Below
Direct share (website + WhatsApp)	62%	57%	+5 pts	60%	On target
Cost per paid booking	Rs 690	Rs 720	−4%	Rs 750	Better

The three insight slides

Headline	Evidence	So what	Now what
Shorter rentals cost us about Rs 600,000 in Q3	Réunion visitors rose from 14% to 24% of bookings; they rent for 3.6 days on average vs 6.4 for Europeans	Meta targeting bought cheap but short rentals; volume up, value down	Move Meta budget to European pre-arrival audiences; launch a 7-day rate on 1 Nov; report rental days monthly
Fast WhatsApp replies double our close rate	1,150 enquiries; replied in under 15 min: 22% booked; after 1 hour: 9%. Median reply time 48 min	About 40 extra bookings a quarter if we reply fast	Reply rota 8:00–20:00, quick replies with prices, greeting message; target median under 15 min
We lose a third of airport searches to budget	Google Ads lost 35% of impression share on "car rental mauritius airport" to budget; cost per booking Rs 530 vs Rs 1,000 on Meta	Cheapest bookings, high intent, European travellers	Move Rs 40,000 a quarter from Meta Réunion to Google Ads Europe; review after 6 weeks

Data note in the appendix: online bookings fell 32% in September after a new booking form went live on 2 September (date picker failed on some phones). Fixed on 3 October; September is excluded from the conversion-rate trend.

The meeting and the result

The QBR took 25 minutes. The owner approved the budget move and the 7-day rate in the meeting and asked for rental days to be added to the weekly pulse. Six weeks later (illustrative): average rental length 5.3 days, median WhatsApp reply time 12 minutes, Google Ads impression share lost to budget down to 12%. The agency kept the client and was asked to present the Q4 review to the owner’s brother, who runs the hotel partnerships.

> **The lesson:** the data was the same before and after. What changed was the choice of KPIs (value, not just volume), one honest source of truth, a dashboard designed for one reader, and a story that started with the answer and ended with a decision.

SECTION 28

Frequently asked questions

How many pages should a monthly report be?

One page of summary and KPIs, plus two or three pages of detail for those who want it. If the owner reads only page 1, they should still know the result, the reason and the decision needed.

Should I use Data Studio or a spreadsheet?

Data Studio for anything shared and updated regularly (live data, scheduled delivery, no copy-paste). A spreadsheet for cleaning, offline data, targets and one-off analysis. Most good reporting systems use both: the Sheet feeds Data Studio.

The client only wants to see likes and followers. What do I do?

Show them, but next to a business metric: "Followers +850; enquiries from Instagram 64, cost Rs 95 each." Over a few months, move the conversation towards results.

My numbers are tiny. Is reporting even useful?

Yes, but report counts, use longer periods (quarter, rolling 3 months) and avoid percentage changes on small bases (Section 11). Qualitative information (what customers say on WhatsApp) also counts.

GA4 and the booking system never match. Which is right?

For totals, the booking system. GA4 misses refused cookies, blocked tags and offline bookings. Use GA4 for the channel split and behaviour, and explain the gap in the data notes (Section 12).

How do I report a month that went badly?

Early, plainly and with a plan: the result, the cause with evidence, what you have already done, what you propose, and a checkpoint (Section 25).

How do I set targets if I have no history?

Start from the business goal and the KPI tree, use the best estimates available (sales team, capacity, seasonality), label them "first estimate" and revise after one quarter.

Can I let AI write the report?

AI can draft and rephrase, but you must check every number and every claimed cause. Never paste personal data into an AI tool (Section 19).

What is the difference between a dashboard and a report?

A dashboard is a live tool that people consult; a report is a document for a period, with interpretation and recommendations. The quarterly report combines both: a dashboard plus a data story.

How long should the QBR presentation be?

About 10 minutes of slides and 15–20 minutes of discussion. Five to seven slides plus an appendix (Section 25).

SECTION 29

Exercises and your Quarterly Report

Your Week 18 deliverable is a **Quarterly Report**: an executive dashboard with a data story and three insight presentations. Use your own business, your employer's (with permission), a client's (with permission) or the free GA4 demo account (Google Merchandise Store) with a Google Sheet of illustrative targets.

Exercise 18.1 · KPI tree and dashboard plan (60 min)

Draw the KPI tree for your business (Section 5) from the business goal to channel metrics. Choose 5–7 executive KPIs, mixing outcome, efficiency and leading indicators (Section 6). Write the KPI dictionary with definition, source, referee and target (Section 7) and sketch the dashboard page on paper using the layout in Section 13.

Exercise 18.2 · Build the executive dashboard (2–3 hours)

In Data Studio, build page 1 (executive) and page 2 (channels) following Section 17: date range control with comparison, 5–7 scorecards with comparisons, a combo chart against target from a blended Google Sheet, a sorted bar chart by channel, a headline text box and an insights box. Run the 5-second and 60-second tests (Section 13) with someone outside the course and note what you changed.

Exercise 18.3 · The Quarterly Report (deliverable)

Part	Content
1. Executive dashboard	Link to the Data Studio report (view access): 5–7 KPIs vs target and last year, two "why" charts, headline and insights box; page 2 for channels
2. Executive summary	The 5-line summary (Section 24): headline vs target, main reason, two other insights, recommendation and ask, outlook and risk
3. Data story	One page or 2 slides: context → complication → resolution → ask (Section 22), answer first
4. Three insight slides	Each with a headline title, one annotated chart, so what (sized) and now what (action, owner, date, KPI) (Sections 20, 23, 25)
5. Next quarter plan	Priorities, budget changes, tests, targets
6. Data notes and KPI dictionary	Sources, referees, definitions, known gaps, what is estimated (Sections 7, 12)

Submit on the learning platform (Module 18): the Data Studio link and a link to your slides (Google Slides or PowerPoint, 6–10 slides including the summary and the three insight slides).

Exercise 18.4 · Excel (90 min)

Download the Week 18 Excel file: a quarter of multi-channel data for a fictional homeware shop. Clean the export with a mapping table, calculate KPIs with MoM, QoQ and YoY changes, summarise by channel and month, choose the right charts and build two, then write three insights and a 5-line executive summary. Scored out of 20.

TEMPLATES

Copy-and-use templates

KPI dictionary

KPI	Definition / formula	Source (referee)	Target	Owner	Notes

Executive summary (5 lines)

1. **Headline:** [Period] [main KPI] was [value]: [x% of target], [change vs last year].
2. **Main reason:** [driver] because [cause, with number].
3. **Other insights:** [insight 2]; [insight 3].
4. **Recommendation and ask:** we propose [action, cost]; we need [decision] by [date].
5. **Outlook / risk:** [next period target] is [reachable / at risk] if [condition]; main risk: [risk].

Insight slide

Headline (full sentence): [what happened and why it matters]
Chart: [one chart, one highlight, one annotation]
So what: [impact on the business, sized in Rs or customers]
Now what: [action] · **Owner:** [name] · **Date:** [when] · **Measured by:** [KPI and target]
Source: [tool, period, base count]

QBR deck outline

Slide	Title (write it as a headline)	Content
1	The answer	Executive summary and the decision needed
2	Scorecard	Dashboard page: KPIs vs target and last year
3–5	Insights 1–3	One insight per slide (template above)
6	Next quarter	Priorities, budget, tests, targets, owners
7	Risks and data notes	Risks, tracking limits, estimates
Appendix	Detail	KPI dictionary, channel tables, methodology

Weekly pulse message

```
Week [n]: [KPI] month-to-date [value] vs target [value] ([on track / behind]).
Unusual: [one thing, with number].
This week we will: [one action].  Dashboard: [link]
```

SECTION 30

Glossary and checklists

Before you send any report

- ☐ The reader, their decision and the period are clear on page 1
- ☐ Headline sentence at the top; 5–7 KPIs, each with a comparison
- ☐ Numbers match the source of truth; VAT, dates and currency consistent
- ☐ Percent change for amounts, percentage points for rates; counts shown for small numbers
- ☐ Every chart title is a headline; one message and one highlight per chart
- ☐ Three insights with so what and now what (owner, date, KPI)
- ☐ Estimates and platform numbers labelled; attribution model stated
- ☐ No personal data; sharing settings checked
- ☐ Executive summary readable on a phone in under a minute

Before the QBR

- ☐ Full report sent the day before
- ☐ 5–7 slides plus appendix; rehearsed with a timer
- ☐ The decision you need is written on slide 1 and on the plan slide
- ☐ Answers ready for the three questions you expect; KPI dictionary in the appendix

Mistakes to avoid

Mistake	Do this instead
Sending every metric "in case"	5–7 KPIs from the KPI tree; detail on later pages
Numbers without comparison	Target, last period or last year on every KPI
Adding up conversions from several platforms	One referee per KPI; platform numbers labelled
"+100%!" on 3 → 6 results	Show counts, use longer periods
Comparing December with November in a seasonal business	Year on year, same days, festivals noted
Titles like "Sessions by channel"	Headline titles that state the finding
Bad news on page 9	Bad news in line 1, with cause and plan
AI-written summary sent unchecked	Check every number and claimed cause

Glossary

Term	Meaning
KPI	Key performance indicator: a metric linked to a business goal, with a target
KPI tree	A breakdown of a business goal into the metrics that drive it
KPI / data dictionary	A table defining each KPI: formula, source, owner, notes
Source of truth (referee)	The system whose number is used when tools disagree
Vanity metric	A metric that looks good but does not guide a decision
Leading / lagging indicator	A metric that predicts results / one that confirms them
Benchmark	A reference value from an industry, platform or your own history
MoM, QoQ, YoY	Month on month, quarter on quarter, year on year comparisons
Percentage point (pt)	The difference between two percentages (2.0% → 2.5% = +0.5 pts)
Seasonality	Regular patterns linked to the time of year, holidays or festivals
Margin of error	The range in which the true value probably lies
Blend / join key	Joining data sources / the common field used to join them
Scorecard	A chart showing one number, usually with a comparison
Executive dashboard	A one-page view of 5–7 KPIs for decision-makers
QBR	Quarterly business review: a meeting to review results and decide the next quarter
Post-mortem	A review after a campaign of what worked and what to change
Insight	An explained, relevant finding that leads to an action
Pyramid principle	Answer first, then supporting reasons, then evidence
Annotation	A short label on a chart explaining an event or point
MER	Marketing efficiency ratio: total revenue ÷ total marketing spend
Incrementality	The extra results a channel really causes, measured by a test